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A PRACTICE GUIDE FROM THE HUSH ROOM

Sacred *Reading.*

Formative Reading · Reading to be shaped, not finished.



Reading spiritual books slowly — stopping when something strikes you, sitting with it before moving on. Reading for formation, not information.

"Blessed is the one whose delight is in the law of the Lord, and who meditates on his law day and night."

Psalm 1:1-2

THE PRACTICE

Two ways to read the same book.

There are two ways to read a spiritual book, and they could not be more different.

Informative reading is the one we know. We pick up the book, we read fast, we extract the argument, we add it to our knowledge, we move on to the next book. We are masters of the text — taking from it what serves us. This is how we read for school, for work, for skill-building. And it is fine for many things. But it is not how spiritual books are meant to be read.

Formative reading is the older way. We pick up the book, we read slowly, we let one paragraph stop us. We sit with it. We do not finish a chapter today — we finish a sentence. We are servants of the text — letting it take from us what needs to go, and put in us what is missing. This is how the early Church read. This is how the desert mothers read. This is how saints have been formed for two thousand years.

It is not he that reads most — but he that meditates most — that will prove the choicest, sweetest, wisest, strongest Christian.

Thomas Brooks · 17th century

When we submit our lives to what we read in Scripture, we find we are not being led to see God in our stories — but our stories in God's. God is the larger context and plot in which our stories find themselves.

Eugene Peterson · Eat This Book

Eugene Peterson, late in his life, said the most important word in his entire ministry was intestinal. Scripture, he insisted, is meant to be eaten — not just read. The Word is food. It is meant to enter you, slowly, change you from the inside out, become part of the very fibre of who you are.

The same is true — in a smaller way — of every good spiritual book that is rooted in Scripture. Henri Nouwen on the Father's love. Ruth Haley Barton on solitude. Brother Lawrence on the presence of God. These are not books you finish. These are books you steep in.

HOW TO READ THIS WAY

Four small practices that change everything.

Sacred reading does not require a different book. It requires a different posture. Try these four practices with whatever good spiritual book is on your shelf.

i. Slow

Read slowly — no chapter goals.

Take off the timer. Cancel the deadline. There is no quiz. The point is not to finish the book this month. The point is to be shaped by it.

Read at the pace of breath. Read aloud sometimes. Read the sentence twice if you want. Five minutes can be a session — if five minutes is what those minutes deserve.

ii. Stop

Stop when something resonates — sit with it.

Notice what stops you. A sentence. An image. A question you didn't expect. The pause is not an interruption — the pause is the point.

Don't analyse why it stopped you. Just stay with it. A minute. Five. As long as it takes for the words to settle into you. Then — and only then — read on.

iii. Journal

Note what you notice — even one sentence.

When something stops you, write it down. The words that struck you. The thought they sparked. A prayer that rose. A memory.

It does not have to be coherent. It does not have to be long. One sentence per reading session is enough. Over time, your journal becomes a record not of what you read — but of how God spoke to you while you were reading.

iv. Ask

Ask — what is God saying to me through this?

This is the question that turns reading into prayer. Not what did the author mean? — though that matters. But what is the Spirit saying to me, here, today, through these words?

Sometimes the answer is clear. Sometimes you sense an invitation you can't yet name. Sometimes there is only silence. All three are good. The asking shapes the listening.

WHERE TO BEGIN

Books that have shaped this ministry.

If you don't know where to start, here are five that have nourished Christians in this contemplative tradition for decades:

Sacred Rhythms **Ruth Haley Barton**

An accessible introduction to the practices that form the soul.

The Practice of the Presence of God **Brother Lawrence**

A 17th-century lay brother's letters on continual prayer.

The Way of the Heart **Henri Nouwen**

Solitude, silence, and prayer drawn from the Desert Fathers.

An Unhurried Life **Alan Fadling**

Following Jesus' own pace of grace through the day.

Eat This Book **Eugene Peterson**

Why Scripture is meant to be tasted, chewed, and digested.

A note: Sacred reading is not the only way to read. Read fast for information when you need information. Read whole books when you want to grasp an argument. But carve out a small daily practice of formative reading — fifteen minutes, a single page — and over a year you will be a different person. The slow reading is the one that re-makes you.

A blessing as you begin.

*May the books on your shelf become teachers,
and the teachers become friends,
and the friends lead you, gently,
back to the One Voice
they all are pointing to.*

The Father waits. The Son welcomes. The Spirit moves.